

Between Two Rivers: Nakajima and Hiroshima's Peace Memorial Park

Where the Ota River forks into the Motoyasu and Hon channels stood Nakajima, a wedge of reclaimed land that grew from reed banks into one of Hiroshima's busiest commercial quarters. The atomic bomb of 6 August 1945 erased it within seconds. On the same ground, planners and the architect Kenzo Tange built Peace Memorial Park. This dossier traces both layers.



平和記念公園・旧中島地区（広島市中区）

In this dossier

- 1. A history of the district (7 chapters, about 1900 words)
- 2. Timeline
- 3. Walking notes, walk map and photographs of the stops
- 4. Then and now: aerial photographs
- 5. How the ground was made
- 6. Disasters remembered
- 7. Sources (19) and further reading

Written in English from Japanese library sources — chiefly books digitised by the National Diet Library — and official records. Superscript numbers point to the numbered sources at the end, with page frames for the digitised books.

A delta built from a river's silt

Hiroshima sits on the delta the Ota River built at the head of the Inland Sea. A 1925 city guide reproduces a geologist's estimate that it took the river's silt roughly one thousand and seventy years to raise the mudflats into land, a slow accumulation that first became habitable as reed-covered sandbars and then, hamlet by hamlet, as farmland. Old villages on the delta were known together as Goka-no-sho, the 'five hamlets,' each said to sit on its own patch of ground like an island in the reeds. Where the river's main branch forked near the tip of one such patch, a 1900 Hiroshima guidebook records, the stream split into an eastern channel called the Motoyasu and a western one called the Hon; the wedge of land reclaimed between them took its name plainly from being in the middle: Nakajima, the 'middle island.'¹²

In 1589 the warlord Mori Terumoto chose this delta, then known as Goka, as the site for a new castle. The castle's own history describes him surveying the site from the hills around the delta before building began that year, and says the name Hiroshima may date from this moment. Terumoto moved into the unfinished castle in 1591; the stone walls were finished in 1593 and the castle in 1599. A commercial guidebook of 1925 sums up what followed: after Terumoto lost the domain at Sekigahara in 1600, the Fukushima and then the Asano lords governed the delta for more than 270 years, and the small trades that grew up under their rule were, the guide notes, still shaping the city's industry in the twentieth century. A companion atlas the city published in 1925 reproduces seven comparative maps of the castle town, from Terumoto's own era to 1877.³⁴⁵

Nakajima under the old regime

By 1900 a guidebook to the city could describe Nakajima precisely: bounded by the Motoyasu River to the east and the Hon River to the west, its northern tip at a bend called Jisenji-no-hana and its southern edge running down to the reclaimed fields of Yoshijima, the district was, in the guide's words, 'just like an islet of its own.' A bridge already crossed the river at the fork, and the same book, which writes its name 相合 ('joined together'), explains it: two spans, east and west, met as one. Nearby stood Motoyasu Bridge, a 28-ken timber span with iron railings on the old national highway, which the guide calls, together with Honkawa Bridge, the busiest crossing in the city.¹

In neighboring Kako-machi stood the district's civic quarter: the prefectural office and prefectural assembly hall, both built in 1878, a prefectural hospital, and, sited by 1900 in Nakajima Shinmachi itself, the city hall and city assembly. Behind the hospital lay Yorakuen, a former Asano-family villa turned public garden with an artificial hill, a pond and a boulder locals said had cost a fortune to move; it opened to visitors only on Sundays and festival days. Two temples anchored the district's religious life: Tenmangu in Tenjin-cho, a shrine to Sugawara no Michizane that Mori Terumoto had transferred from the family's old castle at Koriyama, and Seiganji in Zaimoku-cho, a major Jodo-sect temple whose founder is said to have raised its halls on what was then open reed-flat.¹

A commercial quarter comes of age

War and trade brought Hiroshima's economy a series of jolts. A 1925 commercial guide traces the sequence: the Meiji Restoration opened a 'national economy' era; the wars with China and Russia turned the city into the leading commercial center west of Osaka; and the First World War, together with Ujina harbor, whose construction the prefecture completed in 1889, drew large modern enterprises and made Hiroshima, in the guide's phrase, a hinge between the industrial belt of northern Kyushu and the Hanshin region around Osaka and Kobe. Nakajima Honmachi had been the city's leading shopping street since the last years of the Edo period. Its heyday passed in the 1910s and 1920s, but its shops kept trading, and in March 1929 the kimono merchant Taishoya opened a modern three-story reinforced-concrete store, with a basement, on its main street.^{314 15 19}

Just before the bombing, by the estimate of the city's 1971 war-damage record as reported by the local newspaper, some 1,330 households and 4,370 people lived in the district's seven neighborhood associations: Nakajima Honmachi, the two Tenjin-cho associations, Zaimoku-cho, Kobiki-cho, Moto-yanagi-cho and Nakajima Shinmachi. Family photographs published by the same paper show what was there: a footwear shop on the Tenjin-cho street along the Motoyasu River, a dye shop whose owner and three of his family were killed by the bomb, a trading company on Zaimoku-cho, and on Moto-yanagi-cho a confectioner's branch office in a building that had been a bank's head office until 1927. Upstream, the Aioi Bridge had been rebuilt in 1932 and, in 1934, extended into a distinctive T-shape.¹²¹⁴

6 August 1945

The T-shaped Aioi Bridge, unmistakable from the air, is said to have been the aiming point for the atomic bomb dropped on the morning of 6 August 1945. The bomb missed by about 300 meters and exploded above Shima Hospital, where a clinic of the same name stands today. The blast and heat that followed obliterated Nakajima and the blocks around it, which lay between about 100 and 700 meters from the hypocenter; the city's own account of the district states simply that it suffered total destruction. That morning many students, and people mobilized from neighborhoods and workplaces, were at work clearing buildings for firebreaks around what is now Peace Boulevard; the city's account records that the students who gathered on the riverbanks, burned beyond recognition and begging for water, all died.⁶¹²

Individual buildings tell the same story at closer range. At the Taishoya building, which in wartime had become the 'Fuel Hall' of the prefectural fuel-rationing union, 37 staff were at work when the bomb fell some 170 meters away; every one of them died except Nomura Eizo, who happened to be in the basement fetching papers and became the building's only survivor. At Honkawa Elementary School, 410 meters from the hypocenter, the reinforced-concrete school building burned out completely, leaving only its shell, and then served as a relief station for the injured. The Industrial Promotion Hall, about 160 meters from the hypocenter, burned out too, but because the blast came down on it almost vertically the central part of the building did not collapse.^{7 15 16}

How many died is still not precisely known. The city's own current estimate, reached by combining several postwar surveys, is that approximately 140,000 people, plus or minus 10,000, had died by the end of December 1945 from the bombing's immediate and short-term effects; the city states plainly that this remains an estimate rather than a count of named individuals. Among the dead were Koreans then living or working in Hiroshima under Japan's colonial rule; the Peace Memorial Museum's guide to their memorial says that tens of thousands of Koreans were in the city and exposed to the bomb.⁹¹¹

From ashes to a memorial city

Planning for what would replace Nakajima began astonishingly fast. Hiroshima Prefecture proposed setting aside the hypocenter area as a memorial zone as early as September 1945, a month after the bombing; the city's reconstruction council turned this into a concrete park plan by February 1946; and in November 1946 a park on the Nakajima district was written into the national reconstruction plan for Hiroshima. The legal foundation followed in May 1949, when the Diet passed the Hiroshima Peace Memorial City Construction Law, a special statute that applied to Hiroshima alone; reconstruction, held back until then by a severe shortage of money, only gathered pace after it. A design competition that summer drew 145 entries; the winning scheme, submitted by a group led by the architect Kenzo Tange, set the park's Cenotaph, the ruined Dome and the Peace Memorial Museum on a single sightline running north from the museum's raised colonnade.⁸

Construction followed through the 1950s. Tange's saddle-roofed Cenotaph, its curved form recalling the clay houses once placed on ancient burial mounds, was unveiled on 6 August 1952 and carries an inscription whose English rendering reads 'Let all the souls here rest in peace, for we shall not repeat the evil.' The Peace Memorial Hall was completed in May 1955 and the Peace Memorial Museum in August. The transformation of the old commercial district into parkland was not, however, immediate: barracks put up by people living on the planned park site remained until about 1959, fourteen years after the bombing.⁸¹³

Peace Boulevard, the 100-meter-wide road along the park's southern edge, followed the same slow path. Japan's reconstruction policy of December 1945 had planned 24 roads at least 100 meters wide in seven cities; only three were built, two in Nagoya and this one. In 1955 a candidate who promised to halve its width and build municipal housing on the rest was elected mayor. Persuaded to drop the pledge, he launched a tree-donation campaign instead, and in 1957 and 1958 more than 100,000 trees and saplings arrived from across Japan and abroad to plant the road.¹⁸

Contested memory, added later

Preserving the Dome's skeleton was, for two decades, an open question; some Hiroshima residents wanted the dangerous, painful ruin demolished rather than kept as a landmark. In July 1966 the city council resolved to preserve it, and a fundraising drive raised 66,197,816 yen from donors in Japan and abroad for the first preservation work in 1967. In the early 1990s a nationwide petition asking for World Heritage status, finally signed by 1,653,996 people, was adopted by both houses of the Diet in 1994; the government designated the Dome a national historic site in June 1995 and nominated it that September, and in December 1996 UNESCO inscribed it on the World Heritage List; the city's own framing describes it as a monument meant to convey the bombing's devastation to the whole world.⁷

Other memorials arrived later still, and not without dispute. A memorial to Korean victims of the bomb was erected in April 1970, but outside the park proper, near the west end of Honkawa Bridge. The Peace Memorial Museum's guide explains the site: Prince Yi U, of Korea's royal family, was found near there after the bombing. Calls to move the memorial into the park grew over the following decades, and after talks between the city and those concerned it was moved inside the park in July 1999. The Hiroshima National Peace Memorial Hall for the Atomic Bomb Victims, designed by Tange's firm and built mostly underground, opened on 1 August 2002.¹¹¹⁷

Reading the ground today

Little of Nakajima's street grid survives in the park's lawns, but several fixed points let a visitor locate it. The Dome still stands where the Industrial Promotion Hall did. The Aioi Bridge, rebuilt in 1983 on the same T-shaped plan, still forks toward the park's northern tip close to where the 1900 guidebook placed its wooden predecessor; a newel post from the wartime bridge, still marked by the blast, is kept at the bridge end, and a bent piece of its girder is in the Peace Memorial Museum. The Rest House, once the Taishoya kimono shop and restored in 2020 close to its original look, keeps the basement where Nomura Eizo survived; it is open to visitors.¹²¹⁵

Across the Hon River to the west, part of the gutted Honkawa school building is kept as the school's peace museum. The Cenotaph's sightline to the Dome was drawn by Tange's plan, not inherited from the old town; the old street pattern is easier to find at the Rest House, beside Motoyasu Bridge, the crossing that carried the old highway into Nakajima. On the evening of 6 August, paper lanterns are still floated on the Motoyasu River, a practice the city traces to families of the dead in the years soon after the war.⁸¹⁰¹⁶

Timeline

1589	Mori Terumoto begins building Hiroshima Castle on the Ota River delta, at a site then called Goka. ⁵
1600-1871	After Terumoto's defeat at Sekigahara, the Fukushima and then Asano lords govern the delta for more than 270 years of castle-town growth. ³
1878	The prefectural office and prefectural assembly hall are built in Kako-machi, next to Nakajima. ¹
1889	Construction of Ujina harbor is completed, opening the delta to ocean shipping. ¹⁹
1900	A city guidebook describes Nakajima, between the Motoyasu and Hon rivers, as 'just like an islet of its own.' ¹
1915	The Hiroshima Prefectural Commercial Exhibition Hall, designed by the Czech architect Jan Letzel, is completed; renamed the Industrial Promotion Hall in 1933, it is today's Atomic Bomb Dome. ⁷
1929	The kimono merchant Taishoya opens a three-story reinforced-concrete store on Nakajima Honmachi's main street; later the Rest House. ¹⁵
1932-1934	Aioi Bridge is rebuilt, then extended in 1934 into its distinctive T-shape. ¹²
6 August 1945	The atomic bomb, said to have been aimed at Aioi Bridge, explodes about 300 meters away above Shima Hospital; Nakajima and the surrounding district are destroyed. ⁶¹²
1946-1949	A park on the Nakajima district enters the national reconstruction plan (November 1946); the Diet passes the Hiroshima Peace Memorial City Construction Law (May 1949) and a design competition is won by a group led by Kenzo Tange. ⁸
1952-1955	Tange's Cenotaph is unveiled (6 August 1952); the Peace Memorial Hall and the Peace Memorial Museum are completed (May and August 1955). ⁸
1959	The last barracks on the park site disappear, about fourteen years after the bombing. ⁸
1970-2002	The Korean Atomic Bomb Victims Memorial is erected outside the park (1970); the Dome is listed as a UNESCO World Heritage Site (1996); the Korean memorial is moved inside the park (1999); the National Peace Memorial Hall opens (2002). ⁷¹¹¹⁷

Walking notes

Places to stand and look, in walking order. Straight-line distances only; check today's access and opening before you go.

- 1

Atomic Bomb Dome

原爆ドーム

The skeletal ruin of the 1915 Industrial Promotion Hall, about 160 meters from the hypocenter, left standing because the blast came down on it almost vertically; a UNESCO World Heritage Site since 1996.⁷

map
- 2

Aioi Bridge

相生橋

Rebuilt in 1983 on the same T-shaped plan as the bridge that was the bomb's aiming point; a newel post bearing traces of the blast is kept at the bridge end.¹²

map
- 3

Rest House

レストハウス

Once the Taishoya kimono shop; its basement, where Nomura Eizo survived as the only one of 37 staff at work that morning, is open to visitors.¹⁵

map
- 4

Cenotaph and the north-south axis

原爆死没者慰霊碑

Kenzo Tange's saddle-roofed monument frames the Dome through its arch on a sightline that also runs south to the Peace Memorial Museum; the inscription pledges that 'we shall not repeat the evil.'⁸¹³

map
- 5

Korean Atomic Bomb Victims Memorial

韓国人原爆犠牲者慰霊碑

A turtle-based monument moved into the park in 1999 after 29 years outside it near Honkawa Bridge.¹¹

map
- 6

Honkawa Elementary School Peace Museum

本川小学校平和資料館

Part of the school building gutted by the bomb 410 meters from the hypocenter, a relief station afterwards and now the school's peace museum.¹⁶

map
- 7

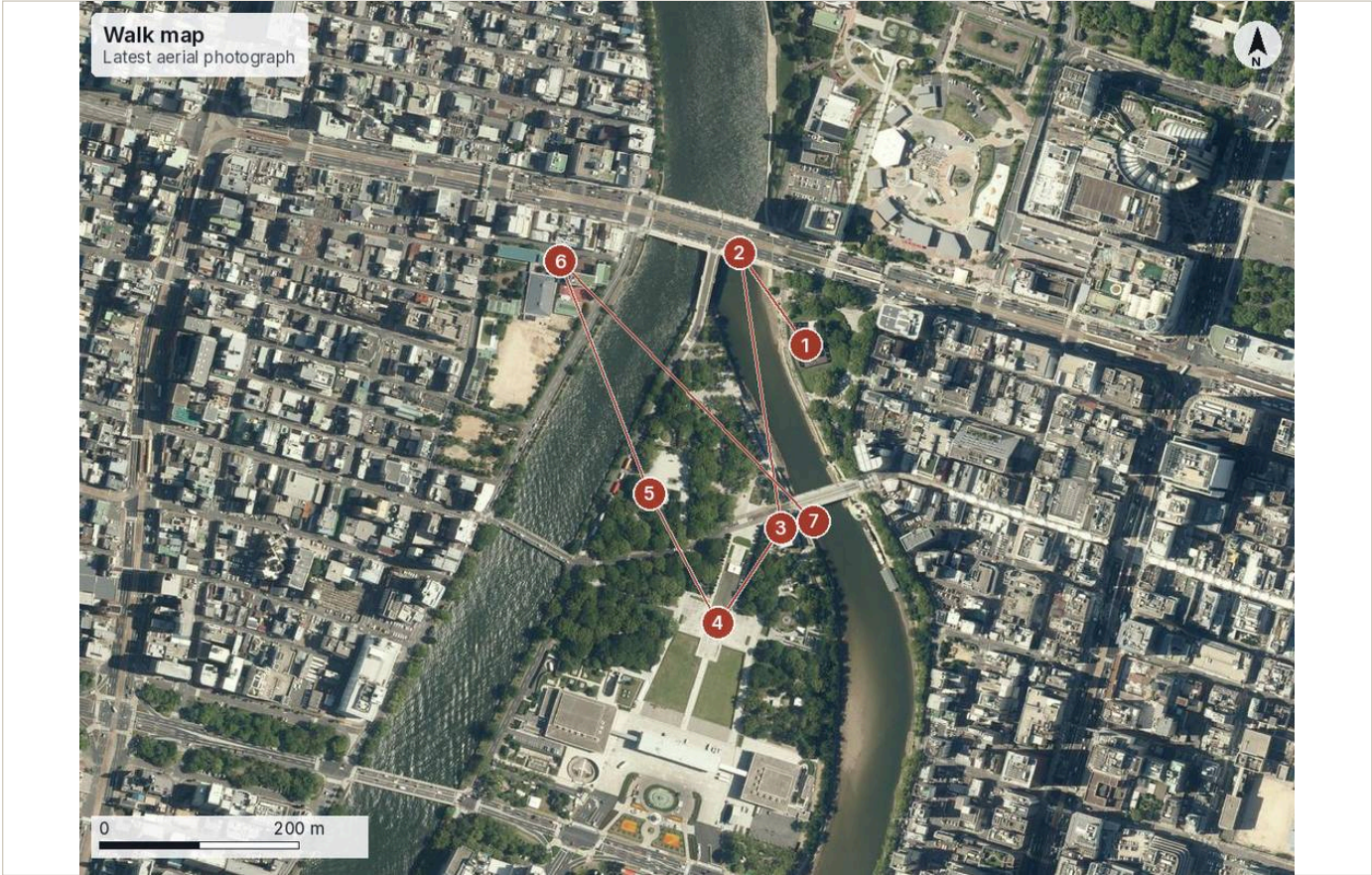
Motoyasu riverbank

元安川河岸

On the evening of 6 August, paper lanterns are floated here in memory of the dead, a practice the city traces to bereaved families in the years right after the war.¹⁰

map

Walk map



The walking stops, numbered as in the notes, on the latest GSI aerial photograph (1.2 × 0.9 km, north up). Lines join the stops in order and are not a route; follow streets on the ground. Each stop in the notes links to a map app.

- 1

Atomic Bomb Dome [map](#)
- 2

Aioi Bridge [map](#)
- 3

Rest House [map](#)
- 4

Cenotaph and the north-south axis [map](#)
- 5

Korean Atomic Bomb Victims Memorial [map](#)
- 6

Honkawa Elementary School Peace Museum [map](#)
- 7

Motoyasu riverbank [map](#)

The stops today

Recent photographs of the stops, numbered as in the walking notes. Each was checked against the place the note describes; the line under the name says what it shows.



1. Atomic Bomb Dome
The Atomic Bomb Dome, with the bare steel frame of its dome
"Genbaku Dome04-r" by Oilstreet, CC BY 2.5, via Wikimedia Commons



2. Aioi Bridge
Newel post of the previous (1932) Aioi Bridge, kept at the Nakajima-cho end
"Old Aioibashi ayahashira02" by Taisyo, CC BY 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons



3. Rest House
The Rest House in Peace Memorial Park after its 2020 renovation
"RestHouse-of-Hiroshima-Peace-Park-renewal2020" by Tokyo-Good, CC BY-SA 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons



4. Cenotaph and the north-south axis
The Cenotaph, with the Atomic Bomb Dome seen through its arch
"Cenotaph for A-Bomb Victims" by j. Miers - User: (WT-shared) Jtesla16 at wts wikivoyage, Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons



5. Korean Atomic Bomb Victims Memorial
The memorial to Korean A-bomb victims, standing on a stone turtle
"Korean Hibakusha Cenotaphs in Hiroshima Peace Park" by Sky Wing Sky, CC BY-SA 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons



6. Honkawa Elementary School Peace Museum
The arched-window building of the Honkawa Elementary School Peace Museum
"Honkawa Elementary School Peace Museum01" by Kiyokun, Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons



7. Motoyasu riverbank
Lanterns floating on the Motoyasu River on 6 August, with the Atomic Bomb Dome on the bank
"Ceremonia de linternas en Hiroshima" by Christian Córdova, CC BY 2.0, via Wikimedia Commons

The same ground, 1961–1969 and 2023



1961–1969 aerial photograph — GSI Tiles *ort_old10*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. North is up; the frame is identical in both images.



2023 annual orthophoto — GSI Tiles *nendophoto2023*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. Capture dates within a mosaic can differ from place to place.

How to compare. Anchor on features that rarely move — river banks, rail lines, shrine and temple grounds, main roads — then look for what changed around them. Differences in tone come from film, camera and season, not from the land itself.

The decades in between

Every further GSI series that covers the same frame, oldest first. Each series is a compilation: photographs within one series were taken on different dates, which is why seams and changes of tone can appear inside a frame.



1945-1950 (US military photography) · GSI Tiles *ort_USA10*, processed



1974-1978 · GSI Tiles *gazo1*, processed



1979-1983 · GSI Tiles *gazo2*, processed



1987-1990 · GSI Tiles *gazo4*, processed

Rivers, shorelines and terraces



Natural landforms as classified by GSI, over a recent aerial photograph in gray. Dark blue outlines mark former river channels.

■ Floodplain and coastal plain 68%	■ Water 21%
■ Natural levee 10%	■ Former water area 9.4%

What the main landforms mean

Floodplain and coastal plain (68%). Low, flat ground of little relief, built from sand and mud left by floods, or former seabed that emerged. River flooding. Ground is softer nearer the coast and shakes somewhat more; liquefaction tendency is strong on coastal plains and somewhat strong on floodplains. Storm surge near the coast.

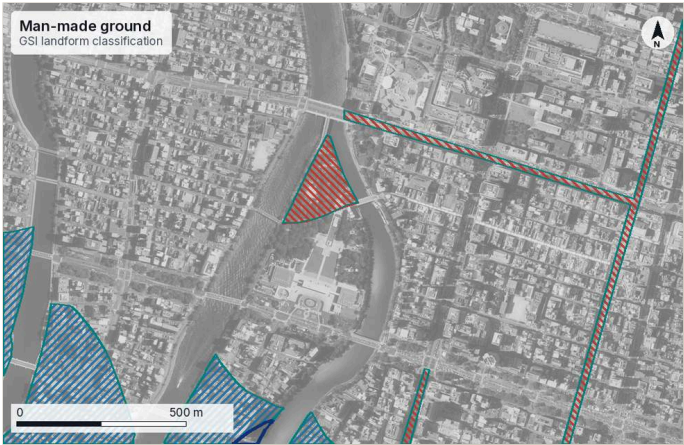
Natural levee (10%). Long, low ridges 0.5 m to a few metres above their surroundings along present or former rivers, built from sediment dropped by floods. Usually above ordinary floods but can be covered in major ones; strong liquefaction tendency at the edges.

Former water area (9.4%). Land shown by old maps and aerial photographs to have been sea, lake, pond, reservoir or river, later turned into land. Soft ground: very strong liquefaction tendency where filled, strong where drained. Storm surge near the coast.

Former river channel (under 0.5%). A former course of a river, slightly lower than its surroundings, cut off when the river moved and later filled with sand and mud. Floodwater stays longer and drains poorly; soft ground amplifies shaking; where filled or raised, the liquefaction tendency is very strong.

Descriptions translated and condensed from GSI's landform-classification legend. They describe tendencies of each landform type, not the condition of any individual plot.

Fill, reclamation and the fields beneath the town



Hatching: man-made ground as classified by GSI. Teal outlines: former sea, river or pond. Dark blue outlines: former river channels.



GSI “Meiji-era lowland” data, traced from topographic maps of the 1880s–1900s; GSI warns that positions can be off by a considerable distance, especially in the Kanto and Kinki regions. Only low, wet or open ground was traced: towns, dry fields and forest of the period are left blank.

Man-made ground

- Polder (drained reclamation) 6.5%
- Filled and reclaimed land 2.9%

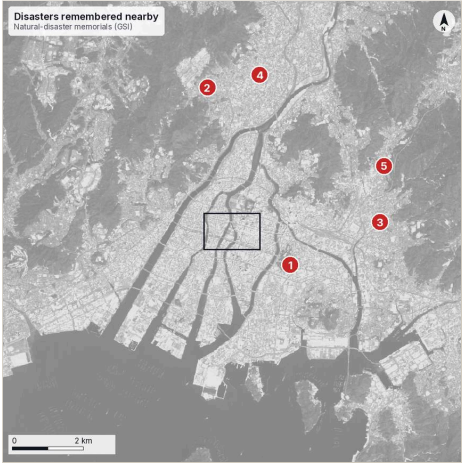
Meiji-era lowland

- River, pond or sea 11%
- Sand and gravel 1.6%
- Tidal flat or beach 1.1%

Polder (drained reclamation) (6.5%). Land made by enclosing water or marsh with embankments and draining it, confirmed from old maps and records. Usually below sea or lake level, so floodwater lingers; storm surge is a particular concern on the coast; soft ground shakes strongly and tends to liquefy.

Filled and reclaimed land (2.9%). Ground raised with fill, land made by dumping soil into the sea, rivers or ponds, or valleys filled in. May flood if not raised enough; on hills, rain or earthquakes can make the fill fail; in lowlands the liquefaction tendency is very strong, especially on filled sea, lake or river beds.

Memorials to natural disasters nearby



Numbered memorials; the black rectangle is the study area of this brief. Frame 16 km across.
Fewer than three memorials stand within 3 km of the study area, so the nearest ones within 8 km are listed.

	Memorial	Disaster	Erected	Distance
1	Memorial to the victims of the landslide of June 1965 慰霊碑	Debris flow (20 Jun 1965) · landslide or debris flow	1966	2.4 km
2	Monument honouring Segawa Uichi for the recovery from the 1926 and 1928 floods 瀬川 卯一翁彰徳碑	Floods and debris flows (1926 and 1928) · flood / landslide or debris flow	1943	5.1 km
3	Memorial to the 1926 flood of the Enokawa and other rivers 水害記念碑	Flood and debris flows (11 Sep 1926) · flood / landslide or debris flow	1944	5.2 km
4	Monument to the 2014 Hiroshima landslide disaster 広島土砂災害	Heavy rain of August 2014 (Hiroshima landslides, 20 Aug 2014) · landslide or debris flow	2014	5.5 km
5	Monument to the flood and debris flows of September 1926 水害碑	Flood and debris flows (11 Sep 1926) · flood / landslide or debris flow	1930	5.8 km

What the memorials record

1. **Memorial to the victims of the landslide of June 1965.** Erected in a corner of a park at the foot of Hijiyama hill to honor those who died in a landslide on 20 June 1965.
2. **Monument honouring Segawa Uichi for the recovery from the 1926 and 1928 floods.** The inscription records the causes and damage of the floods and debris flows brought by torrential rain in 1926 and 1928, and the work of Segawa, head of Yamamoto village at the time, in the recovery.
3. **Memorial to the 1926 flood of the Enokawa and other rivers.** Torrential rain on 11 September 1926 flooded the Enokawa and other rivers. Embankments broke along about 6.4 km and more than 20 bridges were washed away; 3 people died, 26 houses were swept away and 101 were half-destroyed.
4. **Monument to the 2014 Hiroshima landslide disaster.** A red line carved on the monument marks the height of 62 cm above the ground reached by the debris flow of 20 August 2014, passing on to future generations what happened in the disaster.
5. **Monument to the flood and debris flows of September 1926.** The inscription, in classical Chinese, describes the flood and debris flows caused by torrential rain on 11 September 1926 and the damage they did.

Source: GSI Natural Disaster Memorials (自然災害伝承碑). English names and notes are Japan Time Atlas translations and summaries of GSI's Japanese descriptions; the memorials' own inscriptions may say more. "Erected" is the year GSI records for the monument.

Sources

- 林保登 (Hayashi Yasuto), *広島繁昌記：附・厳島* [A record of Hiroshima's prosperity, with Miyajima], 1900; NDL frames 10, 48, 49, 50, 51. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/766312/1/48> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: Delta geography and the six river branches; the Nakajima chapter describing its bounds, the Aioi/Motoyasu bridges, Kako-machi's civic buildings, Yorakuen, Tenmangu and Seiganji.
- 広島広告協会 (Hiroshima Advertising Association), *広島案内* [A guide to Hiroshima], 1925; NDL frames 6, 9, 29. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/914519/1/9> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: Delta formation and a geologist's estimate of its age; the 'five hamlets' before the castle; Aioi Bridge named in 1925.
- 広島商業会議所 (Hiroshima Chamber of Commerce), *広島商工案内 大正14年版* [Hiroshima commercial and industrial guide, 1925 edition], 1925; NDL frame 39. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/958763/1/39> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: Concise history of the delta's economy from the castle town through the Fukushima/Asano domains to the 1920s.
- 広島市 (City of Hiroshima), *広島市史 附図* [History of Hiroshima City: atlas volume], 1925; NDL frames 4, 8, 12, 14, 16, 20, 24. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/965813/1/4> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: Table of contents: seven comparative maps of the castle town from the Mori era to 1877.
- 築城前の広島/広島城築城* [Before the castle / the building of Hiroshima Castle], *広島城* (Hiroshima Castle). <https://hiroshimacastle.jp/history/history01/>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Mori Terumoto's 1589 survey of the site from the surrounding hills; the old name Goka; entry into the castle in 1591, stone walls 1593, completion 1599.
- 29 中島地区* [29. The Nakajima district], 広島市 (City of Hiroshima), reconstruction history series. <https://www.city.hiroshima.lg.jp/atomicbomb-peace/fukko/1021101/1026919/1020931.html>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Nakajima as a leading commercial district from the late Edo period; distance from hypocenter; student mobilization and total destruction.
- 原爆ドームの歴史* [History of the Atomic Bomb Dome], 広島市 (City of Hiroshima). <https://www.city.hiroshima.lg.jp/atomicbomb-peace/1036658/1021107/1015067.html>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: 1915 completion as the Commercial Exhibition Hall and later names; distance from the hypocenter and why the center stood; the preservation debate, the 1966 resolution and the 66,197,816 yen fund; the petition, 1995 historic-site designation and 1996 World Heritage inscription.
- Web展示会「平和記念公園ができるまで」* [Web exhibition: how Peace Memorial Park was built], 広島市 (City of Hiroshima). <https://www.city.hiroshima.lg.jp/tourism-culture/history/1003068/1027532/1008364.html>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The September 1945 memorial-zone proposal, February 1946 park plan and November 1946 national plan; the 1949 law, competition (145 entries) and Tange's axis; Cenotaph 1952; Hall and Museum 1955; barracks until about 1959.
- 原爆で何人が亡くなった（被爆した）のですか。* [How many people died in (were exposed to) the atomic bombing?], 広島市 (City of Hiroshima). <https://www.city.hiroshima.lg.jp/faq/hibakushaengo/1001593/1002276.html>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The city's current casualty estimate, about 140,000 plus or minus 10,000 dead by the end of December 1945, and its acknowledged uncertainty.
- とうろう流しについて知りたい。* [About the lantern-floating ceremony], 広島市 (City of Hiroshima). <https://www.city.hiroshima.lg.jp/faq/atomicbomb-peace/1001618/1002402.html>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Origins of toro nagashi among bereaved families after the war and its present form on 6 August.
- 韓国原爆犠牲者慰霊碑* [Monument guide: the Korean Atomic Bomb Victims Memorial], 広島平和記念資料館 (Hiroshima Peace Memorial Museum). <https://hpmmuseum.jp/modules/xelfinder/index.php/view/2661/11.%20%E9%9F%93%E5%9B%BD%E4%BA%BA%E5%8E%9F%E7%88%86%E7%8A%A0%E7%89%B2%E8%80%85%E6%85%B0%E9%> checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Erection in April 1970 near Honkawa Bridge and the reason for the site; tens of thousands of Koreans exposed to the bomb; relocation into the park in July 1999.
- 相生橋* [Monument guide: Aioi Bridge], 広島平和記念資料館 (Hiroshima Peace Memorial Museum). <https://hpmmuseum.jp/modules/xelfinder/index.php/view/2601/6.%20%E7%9B%B8%E7%94%9F%E6%A9%8B.pdf>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The 1932 rebuilding and 1934 T-shape; the aiming point and the 300-meter miss above Shima Hospital; the 1983 replacement; the newel post and girder kept.
- 原爆死没者慰霊碑（広島平和都市記念碑）* [The Atomic Bomb Memorial Cenotaph], 総務省 (Ministry of Internal Affairs and Communications). https://www.soumu.go.jp/main_sosiki/daijinkanbou/sensai/virtual/memorialsite/hiroshima_hiroshima_002/index.html, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Cenotaph built 6 August 1952 and its inscription.
- 中国新聞 (Chugoku Shimbun), *爆心地近くの中島地区一瞬で消えた街と営み* [The Nakajima district near the hypocenter: a town and its trades erased in an instant]. <https://www.chugoku-np.co.jp/articles/~303620>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Households and population before the bombing (from the city's 1971 war-damage record); the seven neighborhood associations; the shopping street's history and the shops shown in family photographs.
- 建物の歴史* [History of the building], 広島市平和記念公園レストハウス (Peace Memorial Park Rest House). <https://hiroshima-resthouse.jp/history>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The 1929 Taishoya store; its wartime use as the Fuel Hall; the 37 staff, the 170-meter distance and Nomura Eizo's survival; the basement open to visitors.
- 本川小学校平和資料館（本川国民学校）* [Honkawa Elementary School Peace Museum], 広島市 (City of Hiroshima). <https://www.city.hiroshima.lg.jp/atomicbomb-peace/fukko/1021101/1026920/1026921/1020868.html>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Distance from the hypocenter; the burned-out school building, its use as a relief station and today as a peace museum.
- 祈念館について* [About the memorial hall], 国立広島原爆死没者追悼平和祈念館 (National Peace Memorial Hall for the Atomic Bomb Victims). <https://www.hiro-tsuitokinenkan.go.jp/about/>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The Hall's opening on 1 August 2002, its mostly underground building and its designers.
- Yamada Yoshio (NLI Research Institute), *1 0 0 m道路に想う～語り継ぐべき被爆と復興の歴史～* [Thinking about the 100-meter road: a history of the bombing and reconstruction worth retelling], ニッセイ基礎研究所 (NLI Research Institute), 2012. <https://www.nli-research.co.jp/report/detail/id=40080?site=nli>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The 100-meter roads of the December 1945 reconstruction policy (24 planned in seven cities, three built); slow reconstruction until the 1949 law; the 1955 mayoral pledge to halve Peace Seiki Boulevard and the 1957-58 tree-donation campaign.
- 広島港の歴史* [History of the Port of Hiroshima], 広島県 (Hiroshima Prefecture). <https://www.pref.hiroshima.lg.jp/soshiki/221/portofhiroshimahistory.html>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Completion of Ujina harbor's construction in 1889.

Further reading

- 爆心：中島の生と死（朝日新聞広島支局著, 1986）* — An Asahi Shimbun Hiroshima bureau history focused specifically on the Nakajima district's life and death; full-text hits on 中島本町 etc. at frames 2, 5, 7, 8, 13, 21, 31, 42, 60, 69. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/9576022> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))
- 原爆モニュメント物語（広島県歴史教育者協議会編著, 1984）* — A history of the park's individual monuments compiled by a history teachers' association; full-text hits at frames 6, 7, 14, 15, 17, 21, 22, 62, 99. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/11926172> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))
- がんす横丁 第2巻（薄田純一郎編, 1973）* — An oral-history and anecdote collection of old Hiroshima street life, with repeated hits on Nakajima Honmachi, Zaimoku-cho and Sarugaku-cho. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/9572791> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))
- 新修広島市史 第1巻 総説編（広島市, 1961）* — The city's standard postwar general history, cited repeatedly by prefectural and municipal library reference-desk answers about this district. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/3008320> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))
- きみはヒロシマを見たか：広島原爆資料館（高橋昭博, NHK取材班著, 1982）* — An account centered on the Peace Memorial Museum's early history and its long-serving director Takahashi Akihiro, himself a survivor. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/12116363> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))

Where a Deep Research request would go next

- Detailed maps and case files of the 1945 bombing-demolition (firebreak) program in Nakajima and neighboring blocks, including which houses were cleared and who was mobilized** — Hiroshima City Archives (広島市公文書館). Consult 広島原爆戦災誌 and city planning records in the reading room, or search the archive's own catalogue for 建物疎開.
- Original prints and negatives of Kikuchi Shunkichi's September 1945 photographs of the ruined Nakajima district, of which only thumbnails are indexed online** — The collection's holding institution, discoverable via Japan Search / the National Diet Library. Search Japan Search for 菊池俊吉写真集 and follow the item's holding-institution link to request access.
- Names, testimonies and family records of the students and teachers killed while clearing firebreaks on 6 August 1945, including those working in or near Nakajima** — Hiroshima Peace Memorial Museum's testimony archive and the National Peace Memorial Hall's victim registry. Contact the museum's research section or search the Hall's online registry of names.
- Municipal and prefectural administrative files on the 1946-1959 reconstruction of the park, including the removal of postwar barrack housing** — Hiroshima City Archives and the Hiroshima Prefectural Library and Archives. Request the city's reconstruction-project files (復興事業関係文書) and reconstruction-era photograph collections.
- US wartime reconnaissance and Strategic Bombing Survey material on Hiroshima, including pre- and post-bombing aerial photographs of the Nakajima area** — US National Archives (NARA), Record Groups 243 (US Strategic Bombing Survey) and 18/373 (military aerial photography). Search the NARA online catalog and order digitized or physical reproductions.

Caveats

- Casualty totals for the bombing remain officially uncertain; this dossier uses the city's own current estimate (about 140,000 plus or minus 10,000 dead by the end of December 1945), which the city itself describes as an estimate rather than a count of named individuals.
- Several early-twentieth-century civic buildings described here (the prefectural office, city hall, hospital, Yorakuen) stood in the adjoining blocks of Kako-machi and Nakajima Shinmachi rather than on the Nakajima Honmachi islet itself; this dossier follows each source's own place names rather than imposing modern district boundaries retroactively.
- The 1900 guidebook's OCR text is corrupted in places; a passage purporting to explain a personal-name origin for Motoyasu Bridge was too garbled to use with confidence and has been omitted.
- The 1900 guidebook writes the bridge at the fork as 相合橋; today's Aioi Bridge is written 相生橋. The guidebook places it at the same fork, but no source consulted states outright that the two names belong to the same crossing.

